

Data Analyst

"You spend most of your day cleaning messy data and turning it into charts and dashboards that answer business questions other people are too busy to investigate themselves."

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Promising — go in with eyes open

Data Analyst could work: your strongest signal is skill fit (77/100), your biggest watch-out is AI resilience (50/100). You caught the AI coworker's mistake — exactly the human judgment this field still pays for.

Reality Score breakdown



The reality snapshot

Median pay: \$112,590/yr (2024) · Entry level: \$63,650 · Job outlook: +34% (2024-2034)

AI exposure: 58/100. Routine SQL pulls, basic chart-building, and first-pass exploratory analysis are increasingly automated by AI copilots and natural-language BI tools. What survives is framing the right question, judging data quality, understanding business context, and defending conclusions to skeptical stakeholders. Pure 'pull this number' analysts are most exposed; analysts who own a domain and influence decisions are far safer.

The part nobody tells you: Roughly 60-80% of the job is unglamorous data cleaning and reconciliation: chasing why two reports disagree by 3%, fixing broken joins, and re-running the same pull because a stakeholder changed the definition of 'active user' midweek. The analysis everyone imagines is a small slice of the actual work.

Your money plan

Chosen path: Public university (in-state) (4 years, \$107,088 tuition) · Region: US national average
Estimated debt after aid + part-time work: \$42,962 · Starting salary: \$63,650 · Break-even: 5.6 years
Manageable but real: ~\$488/mo in loan payments against a 63,650 start.

Your next 30 days

1. Learn SQL hands-on

Complete a free SQL course (Mode SQL Tutorial or Khan Academy) and write 50+ queries against a sample database until JOINS and GROUP BY feel automatic.

2. Get fluent in spreadsheets

Build pivot tables, XLOOKUP, and charts in Excel or Google Sheets using a real public dataset (e.g. NYC 311 calls or a Kaggle CSV).

3. Start the Google Data Analytics Certificate

Enroll on Coursera and finish the first 2-3 courses to cover the analysis workflow and basic R/spreadsheet skills.

4. Learn one BI tool

Download Power BI Desktop (free) or Tableau Public and rebuild one of your spreadsheet analyses as an interactive dashboard.

5. Mini project: end-to-end analysis

Pick a public dataset, write a question, clean the data in SQL/Python, build a dashboard, and write a one-page recommendation. This is your portfolio centerpiece.

6. Publish and share

Put the project on GitHub and Tableau Public with a clear README, then write a short LinkedIn post explaining what you found and how.

Verify it yourself

Primary source — U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics: <https://www.bls.gov/ooh/math/data-scientists.htm>

<https://www.bls.gov/ooh/math/data-scientists.htm>

<https://www.bls.gov/oes/current/oes152051.htm>

<https://www.bls.gov/news.release/ecopro.nr0.htm>

<https://registrar.berkeley.edu/tuition-fees/fee-schedule/>